perseverance, integrity and their never-give-up spirit laid the solid foundation of our nation. These people helped build the incredible institutions that have stood the test of time and continue to be institutions of excellence which in turn make the nation incredible.

Incredible Indians: 75 People Who Shaped Modern India is a homage to some of the people who fought against all odds, surmounted various obstacles and triumphed through their achievements and sacrifices. Behind these seventy-five, there are hundreds, thousands and millions who silently helped these titans achieve their goals and realize their dreams. Nation-building could be compared to a war; even though the victory garland is for the triumphant general, every soldier who fights the battle contributes to the win. Nation-building, too, needs hundreds of thousands of unsung workers who deserve our appreciation. Today, when there is a dearth of living icons who inspire, the lives of these seventy-five iconic Indians need to be highlighted and celebrated. Our present and future generations must read these incredible stories, learn from them and be inspired by them. What one must understand is that behind each of these profiles is the determination and courage of these people to overcome adversity.

APJ Abdul Kalam studied under street lanterns and went on to become India’s Missile Man.

While in jail for fighting for India’s freedom, Abul Kalam Azad did not succumb to adversity and used the opportunity to educate and enlighten himself to become India’s first minister of education.

In the early part of his life, Mohandas Gandhi failed at almost everything he tried, be it his education, profession or his family life. But when push came to shove he did not give up and fought back courageously, learnt from his failures and turned them into his strengths. The rest as they say is history.

Although, eventually, we won freedom because of the non-violent freedom movement, the revolutionaries made a handsome contribution to the nationalist movement and its ultimate success. The Azad Hind Fauj was